

The River Fleet

No. 127

THE HERITAGE of FLEET STREET

April 2026

The River Fleet is only 5 miles long, rising from the Whitestone Pond in Hampstead to join the Thames near Blackfriars Bridge.

The walk starts at Farringdon Station. The Fleet Telephone exchange was built here in 1923. Oyster shells were unearthed in the foundations, recalling John Gay's eighteenth century description of oyster tubs along the Fleet Ditch.

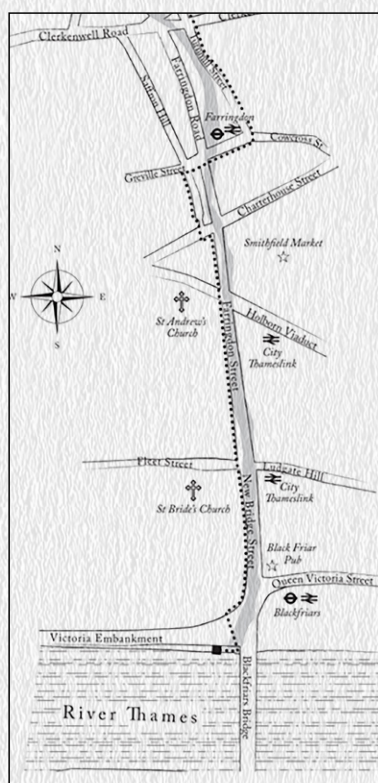
This area was well-known for its cluster of prisons, with medieval Ludgate Prison and its successor Newgate Gaol (on the site of the Old Bailey) further up the river bank. On the left side of Farringdon Road was the Fleet Prison, built during the twelfth century and burned down three times: during the Peasant's Revolt, in the Great Fire and during the Gordon Riots. The Earl of Surrey, John Donne, William Wycherley, Hogarth's Tom Rakewell, and Mr Pickwick all spent time in the Fleet Prison. The prison was contained within the Liberty of the Fleet, beyond the authority of the City. This led to a boom in unlicensed Fleet Marriages until the 1753 Marriage Act ended the industry. As many as thirty couples, often runaways, married here every day. The prison was demolished in 1846.

Continue along Farringdon Street as it crosses Ludgate Circus and becomes New Bridge Street.

Ludgate Circus is an ancient crossing point, where a ford took Fleet Street across the river. It was replaced by a bridge in 1197. Wren built four bridges over the Fleet after the Great Fire, at Holborn, Fleet Lane, Fleet Street, and Bridewell. Stones from his Fleet Street Bridge were re-discovered in 1999, embedded in the Fleet sewer under Ludgate Circus.

New Bridge Street was built in 1765 from Fleet Street to the Thames, covering the remaining stretch of Wren's New Canal.

Bridewell Lane marks the site of a holy well dedicated to St Bride. On the other side are the offices of Bark and Co Solicitors, whose building is the original prison gatehouse and gate of Bridewell Prison. Bridewell Palace was built for Henry VIII in 1515 and named after the holy well of St Bride. The palace was the location for Holbein's



The River Fleet

painting, *The Ambassadors*. Edward VI later donated Bridewell to the city as a prison. It closed in 1855 and the Tudor building was pulled down in the 1860s, leaving only the gatehouse.

Until the dissolution of the monasteries in 1536, the mouth of the Fleet was dominated by the Whitefriars Monastery on the west side and Blackfriars Monastery on the east.

Whitefriars was founded in the thirteenth century by hermits driven from Mount Carmel in the Holy Land. After dissolution, the site became the Liberty of Whitefriars, also known as Alsatia. Exempt from the jurisdiction of both the City and Temple authorities, it became a self-governing enclave providing refuge for criminals and those escaping arrest.

Opposite, at Tudor Street, cross New Bridge Street and turn right, walking along to the Black Friar pub.

The Black Friar, London's only Art Nouveau pub, features a mosaic over the entrance illustrating the monastery and the Fleet. It stands on part of the site of Blackfriars Monastery, built in 1221. Blackfriars was used as a meeting place for Parliament, the Privy Council and the Archbishop of Canterbury's Council. John Wycliffe was denounced for heresy there, and Katherine of Aragon's divorce trial took place in Blackfriars Hall. After dissolution, buildings on the site became an indoor theatre used by Burbage, Shakespeare and the King's Men. Shakespeare also lived in one of the old monastery gatehouses.

Opposite, Watergate marks the old river bank where Bridewell Prison's river gate stood. Between here and the Thames is the Victoria Embankment, completed by Sir Joseph Bazalgette in 1870. Bazalgette introduced three cross-town sewers that still drain much of the Fleet's flow – the High-Level Sewer at King's Cross, the Middle-Level Sewer at Holborn, and the Low-Level Sewer at Blackfriars. The buried Fleet crosses underneath in a storm drain. At Blackfriars, the sewers form a complex underground system with fourteen-foot-high storm relief tunnels, closed by three-tonne metal doors that flip open when storm water comes rushing through.